COVER STORY

THE BIG ITCH

AS SKIN AILMENTS RISE ACROSS THE COUNTRY, NEW DIAGNOSTIC TOOLS AND TREATMENTS OFFER FASTER, MORE EFFECTIVE RELIEF

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A tiny tingling that starts in the skin. One that refuses to go. Till you have scratched it. That is the itch for you, a basic, universal urge as familiar as breathing perhaps. And humans are itching more than ever before—the Global Burden of Disease (GBD) data show an 83 per cent rise worldwide between 1990 and 2021, from 44.1 million to 80.7 million prevalent cases. In a survey of 50,552 people across 20 countries, a 2024 study published in the *British Journal of Dermatology* found 39.8 per cent had scratched an itch in the past week. Among the 3,000 Indians surveyed, 42.6 per cent said they had done so.

Everyone itches from time to time. So, what is new? New research confirms an old intuition: an itch may be no mere a surface problem but the symptom of a deeper underlying malaise. And that picking a random old cream off the shelf or from the local chemist may not be sufficient to get rid of it. The skin is the largest organ in the human body, and an itch is its way of signalling that something is irritating it. Specialised nerve endings respond to triggers, release chemical signals called histamines and send them to the brain which in turn creates the urge to scratch. And while an ordinary itch is harmless, one that lasts for more than six weeks, what in medical parlance is classified as chronic pruritus, could signify that the problem may be more than skin deep. An itch that persists, returns or refuses to respond to treatment, warrants medical investigation.

Indian dermatology literature is increasingly focusing on sensitive skin, stubborn eczema and recurrent fungal disease. A 2025 Indian expert position statement published in *Frontiers in Medicine* described sensitive skin, marked by itching, redness and dryness, as a significant dermatological concern in India and pointed to climate, pollution and everyday exposures as important influences. "We are seeing more patients in whom an itch is no longer a one-off episode; it keeps coming back because the underlying trigger has not gone away," says Dr Monica Bambroo, head of dermatology and cosmetology at Artemis Hospital in Gurugram. Drug-resistant skin fungal infections are another area of concern, where the fungus has changed in a way that makes commonly used antifungal medicines less effective.